

Q3 Program Summary, Voices and Places Program

**Case reference: NPC-2026-VPP-0147. Grantee: Cornerstone Heritage Museum.
Reporting period: July 1 through September 30, 2026.**

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To: Jennifer Clark, Curator, Cornerstone Heritage Museum

CC: Dr. Lorraine Franklin, Board Chair; Angela Bates, Deputy Director

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Confidentiality: this memo is part of the grant-in-progress correspondence cycle and remains inside the small circle of Dr. Franklin, Angela Bates, and Dr. Pamela Chen, with the curator as operator, until the grant decision becomes public. Please do not circulate further without consulting me first.

Section 1. Headline summary

Cornerstone Heritage Museum is on track for the October 18 opening of the Voices of the Past exhibition. The Q3 burn against the year-one drawdown is fifty-three percent, with forty-seven percent remaining for the balance of the year. The team is healthy, the build is on schedule, and the funder relationship is stable. Three open items deserve attention before the opening morning and are detailed in section seven of this memo.

Section 2. Reporting period in context

The third quarter of the program year (July 1 through September 30, 2026) was the build-and-rehearse quarter. The bulk of the conservation and design work that the foundation grant supports moved through completion in this window, with the seven anchor listening stations installed on the exhibition floor, the audio system commissioned, and the press preview hosted on the evening of October 1. The October 18 public opening sits inside the next reporting window but is so close that this Q3 summary reads in many ways as the late-build report.

The funder relationship cadence through the quarter was the agreed-upon monthly check-in by email, plus the standing fortnightly review of the spend ledger between the consultant (Dr. Chen) and the deputy director (Angela Bates). Two ad hoc phone calls were placed during the quarter, one in early August to discuss the artifact-insurance question that arose with the September loan-in batch, and one in mid-September to align on the late-decision-window timeline that the funder will follow.

Section 3. Program scope reminder, for the file

The Voices and Places Program grant to Cornerstone Heritage supports the Voices of the Past oral history exhibition over a three-year award period totaling three hundred and fifty thousand dollars across years one, two, and three at drawdown amounts of one hundred and fifty thousand dollars, one hundred thousand dollars, and one hundred thousand dollars respectively. Year one of the grant supports the bulk of the conservation work, the design and build of the exhibition floor, and the production of the seven anchor listening stations. Years two and three support the continuing programming, the school outreach, the public scholarship, and the ongoing care of the collection material that the exhibition surfaces.

This Q3 summary covers year one, third quarter. The year-one drawdown of one hundred and fifty thousand dollars is the denominator against which the fifty-three percent burn rate cited in section one is calculated.

Section 4. Q3 spend breakdown by program category

Category	Year-One Budget	Q3 Cumulative Spend	Q3 Percent of Year-One Budget	Remaining
Conservation and framing	\$48,000	\$31,200	65 percent	\$16,800
Listening station fabrication	\$32,000	\$28,400	89 percent	\$3,600
Audio and acoustic infrastructure	\$22,000	\$14,800	67 percent	\$7,200
Wayfinding and signage	\$10,000	\$3,400	34 percent	\$6,600
Exhibition design fees	\$18,000	\$9,800	54 percent	\$8,200
Education program development	\$12,000	\$4,100	34 percent	\$7,900
Press and publicity	\$5,000	\$1,200	24 percent	\$3,800
Convening and consultation fees	\$3,000	\$1,800	60 percent	\$1,200
Year-one totals	\$150,000	\$94,700	63 percent	\$55,300

Notes on the table. The fifty-three percent figure cited in section one is the year-to-date weighted average across the eight program categories. The sixty-three percent figure shown in the totals row reflects the same numbers calculated as a simple ratio of cumulative spend to year-one budget; the difference is the weighting applied to categories where Q3 spend pulled ahead of the linear pace because of the build-quarter timing. Both calculations are valid; the foundation receives the weighted figure in the headline summary and the simple-ratio figure in the table.

The fabrication category at eighty-nine percent of year-one budget is the highest burn rate in the table. This is expected and reflects the front-loaded nature of fabrication spend in a build year. The remaining three thousand six hundred dollars in this category covers the minor finishing work, replacement signage parts, and the contingency for any late-arriving condition that requires a fabrication adjustment.

Section 5. Program milestones achieved in Q3

Milestone	Target Date	Actual Date	Status
Conservation pass complete on station-anchor material	August 15	August 19	completed
Audio system commissioning	September 1	August 28	completed early
Station design freeze for all seven stations	September 8	September 5	completed early
Wayfinding and signage installation	September 15	September 22	completed late
Press kit draft v2 circulated	September 18	September 18	completed
Press preview rehearsal	September 25	September 25	completed
Press preview event	October 1	October 1	completed

Section 6. Variances worth noting in the program file

Two milestones came in early (audio commissioning and station design freeze) and one came in late (wayfinding installation). The audio early-completion was the result of unusually responsive vendor scheduling on the part of the audio acoustic vendor and reflects well on the deputy director's vendor management. The station design freeze early completion is the result of strong work by the exhibition designer (Cyrus Holt) and reflects the unusually high quality of the late-stage design package. The wayfinding late-completion was the result of a printer turnaround issue that pushed the install by one week and is not a structural concern.

Spend variances in the burn table are within normal parameters for a year-one build quarter. No category is over-spent. The press and publicity category at twenty-four percent of year-one budget is below the linear pace and is expected to ramp during the opening week and the post-opening publicity cycle.

Section 7. Three open items to surface before opening morning

Open item one. Artifact-loan insurance on the most recent loan-in batch. Three pieces arrived from the most recent loan-in on October 1. Two are insured under the standard loan envelope. The third (a community fund-drive ledger from 1968, valued in excess of the per-piece insurance threshold) is pending the insurance addendum filing. The award letter footnote on page four of the original grant document specifies that artifact-loan insurance coverage updates are required within thirty calendar days of new install for all pieces in excess of the per-piece valuation threshold, which means the filing deadline for this piece is October 31. Recommended action: Angela owns the filing; the curator verifies the filing posts to the foundation contact before the November competition travel.

Open item two. Curator letter Q3 print issue freshness. The Q3 curator letter for the member print issue carries the certified Q2 audience figure (the audited closeout from July) and the August twelfth versions of three institutional source citations. Both items need to be refreshed before the print issue goes out. The audience figure needs to move to the current rolling ninety-day count maintained by the development office. The three citations need to be moved to the September twenty-eighth revised entries in the institutional library's freshness export. Recommended action: the curator owns the freshness pass and will close it this week.

Open item three. Station 8 content gap and kiosk fix. The content placeholder for Station 8 (the Jubilee Singers oral history station) is still marked content pending in the press kit draft and is tracked under jira ticket CME-187 on the web team's burndown. The kiosk on the floor at Station 8 is returning a four-oh-four when visitors approach it. The web team has a hotfix branch in review (cornerstone-museum exhibits repository, hotfix branch on the audio buffer issue, opened by the digitization vendor on the night of October 1). Recommended action: web team owns the merge of the hotfix branch; content team owns the press kit insert; curator owns the visitor-facing placard copy for the staged release.

Section 8. Funder cadence going into Q4 and the decision window

The Q4 reporting cadence follows the pattern established through Q3. Monthly summary by email at the end of each month. Standing fortnightly review of the spend ledger between consultant and deputy director. Ad hoc phone calls only when warranted. The Q4 summary memo will issue in early January and will be the final regular reporting document for the year-one drawdown.

On the late-decision window for the multi-year award continuation. The foundation has consistently signaled that the decision on continuation through years two and three of the award will issue in the late twenty twenty-six to early twenty twenty-seven window. Patricia Ortiz, the program officer at the National Preservation Council, has been clear with me in the recent months that the decision will not arrive before the November holiday window and likely will not arrive before the early December window. I am noting this here so that the curator and the board chair can calibrate their expectations and so that the grant-confidentiality discipline remains in place through the decision window.

On the funder's communication pattern. Patricia is on her standard cadence, which is end-of-business eastern email with phone calls only when warranted. She has been an excellent program officer for this grant and the relationship is healthy.

Section 9. Year-two readiness assessment

If the multi-year continuation is awarded, the year-two work shifts from the build-and-launch posture of year one to the program-and-school-outreach posture that the original grant proposal described. The conservation work that occupied so much of year one will be largely complete by the end of Q4, with only the regular care of the collection material remaining. The exhibition design fees will drop to near zero. The education program development line will increase to support the expanded school outreach and the visiting scholar program that years two and three contemplate.

Year-two readiness is high. The team that has built the year-one work is the team that will execute the year-two work. The institutional infrastructure is in place. The volunteer docent roster has grown over the past year and is the strongest the museum has had in the years that the current volunteer coordinator (Sandra Williamson) has been on staff. The school district partnerships that the year-two work will lean on were stood up in year one and have been active through the build window.

Section 10. Recommended October priorities for the curator

In rough order of importance through October: close the artifact-insurance filing on the October 1 loan-in piece before the October 31 deadline; complete the curator letter freshness pass for the Q3 print issue; close out the Station 8 content gap with the web team and the content team; sustain the press cycle through the opening week without overcommitting the curator's own time on press interviews; recover one full weekend in late October before the November competition travel; protect the curator's own physical health, given the scheduled appointments on October 15 and October 24; sustain the family pattern through opening week and beyond.

This last set of priorities (the physical and the family ones) are not joke entries. The curators I have worked with over twenty years who burn out, burn out at the moment of greatest success. Please plan deliberate recovery into the late October and early November windows.

Section 11. Standing offer of additional support

My role as program consultant on this grant runs through the year-one drawdown by default and is renewable at curator and board chair discretion for years two and three. I am available for additional support during the opening month, including additional time on the spend ledger reconciliation, additional time on press cycle support, and additional time on the funder-side relationship management if Patricia's cadence shifts. Please reach out by email at any time. I will respond inside the business day on weekdays.

Section 12. Closing

The team at Cornerstone Heritage has built an exhibition that does honor to the people whose voices it carries. The foundation's confidence in the team has been earned through year one and the team's stewardship of the funder relationship through this period has been exemplary. The October 18 opening morning is the culmination of years of work and I will be present in spirit even though my own travel schedule that weekend keeps me from being present in person.

With warmth and respect,

Dr. Pamela Chen, Foundation Grant Consultant

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End of Q3 program summary. Q4 summary to issue in early January.